

The Quest to Advance Japanese Language Education in Kenya: Insights from a 2023 Needs Survey

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Abstract:

Japanese language education in Kenya (hereafter, JLEK) is claimed to have begun in 1975 (Japan Foundation, 2023). Since then, several institutions have introduced Japanese language programs, with the language mainly being taught in tertiary institutions as a non-credit optional course, elective course, or minor degree program.

There are several publications documenting the state of JLEK to date. However, there has been a gap in terms of conducting periodic needs surveys that seek the collective views of the instructors and learners towards the advancement of JLEK.

This paper presents the findings of a needs survey conducted on JLEK in the second half of 2023 targeting the above-mentioned respondents. It was deemed important to include potential learners and past learners to better understand, among other things, the barriers encountered in the quest to access, or to continue accessing JLEK.

Based on the survey results, the author examines the possible catalysts for promoting, as well as the barriers impeding, the advancement of JLEK. Considering the challenges facing JLEK as of 2023, such as difficulties in accessing Japanese language programs due to various reasons that are discussed in this paper, challenges in achieving adequate teacher training, and issues regarding teaching and learning materials, the author briefly recommends some remedies through which JLEK can be improved. These include investing in local training programs for instructors, the provision of Japanese programs to the public by (preferably) all institutions implementing JLEK, and the development of materials designed for Kenyan learners of Japanese that are suitable for self-study.

keywords : Japanese language education in Kenya (JLEK), needs survey, Japanese language learners in Kenya, Japanese language teaching and learning materials, Japanese language teacher training

1. Introduction and aim of the survey

As of December 2023, there were 2 systems of education in Kenya running concurrently. The 8-4-4 system, which began in 1985, involves 8 years of primary, 4 years of secondary, and 4 years of university education. The new 2-6-3-3-3 system, which began in 2017, entails 2 years of pre-primary, 6 years of primary, 3 years of lower secondary, 3 years of senior school, and 3 years of tertiary education. The two systems incorporate the

teaching of French, Arabic, and German, while the new system includes Mandarin as the fourth foreign language (KICD, 2017). The national language of Kenya is Kiswahili, while the official languages are Kiswahili and English. English is the language of instruction in Kenyan schools. As of 2024, Japanese is not part of the Kenyan educational curriculum.

This study evaluates the results of a needs survey targeting instructors, learners (current, past and potential learners), and institutions implementing JLEK, conducted by the author from mid-June to early December 2023 (a total of 5.5 months) with the aim of revealing the situation of JLEK (as of 2023), and to provide a basis for recommendations to be made towards its advancement.

2. Background

Japan Foundation (2024b) reports that there were 26 institutions, 44 instructors, and 1,726 learners (31.4% of those learners being from tertiary institutions) engaged in JLEK in 2021. No new comprehensive statistical data for the period after 2021 has been published by JF as of August 2024.

According to Japan Foundation (2024b), actual Japanese language learning mainly happens in tertiary institutions, and majority of the 44 instructors and the 26 institutions reported were of lower learning levels. The report also briefly mentions the lack of qualifications in the case of teachers at lower learning institutions, where only introductory level Japanese language/culture is taught through Japanese clubs as an extracurricular activity. Additionally, it is noted that no institutions/programs offering full-fledged Japanese language teacher training have been identified in Kenya. A summarized overview of JLEK for the period until March 2024 is given in the report; though, detailed information was not gathered, especially from learners.

From its beginning in 1975 at the Japan Africa Culture Interchange Institute (Japan Foundation 2024b), various achievements and challenges have been documented on JLEK. Notable among the challenges is that no national curriculum of JLEK has been developed, despite the language being taught for about 5 decades. Satomi (2016) reports that in some cases, Japanese language teaching has been conducted without the guidance of a syllabus and other necessary elements. Moreover, the Japanese language teaching and learning materials used in Kenya over the years have not been designed with Kenyans as target users (Kagama, 2024). The dire need for the development of a Japanese language education (JLE) curriculum and materials that are friendly to Kenyan learners/instructors of Japanese has been emphasized by Kagema (2023; 2024) and Wamuti (2021). Curriculum development is a process that should consider the prevailing circumstances and needs of its targets (Mabwe, 2015) and, therefore, a needs survey can be said to be crucial in guiding stakeholders of JLEK when developing a curriculum.

Regarding the teaching/learning materials in use, past publications on JLEK highlight *Minna no Nihongo* as the main textbook in use. However, the validity of *Minna no Nihongo* for Kenyan learners of Japanese has been questioned by Arisue (2014a; 2014b), where the author highlights that the setting of the book is in Japan, yet Kenyan learners hardly have any chances to go to Japan, and that it is grammar-based without giving attention to self-expression and productive skills. Additionally, Kagema (2023) notes that Japanese language textbooks are not sold in Kenya, necessitating learners to rely on books that were donated many years ago by the Japan Foundation (JF), and that the number of textbooks available is not enough in relation to the number of learners.

Securing a stable number of Japanese language instructors in Kenya has also been a consistent problem in the last decade, with Arisue (2014b) describing how the poor remuneration/working conditions in private language schools, stemming from issues such as the inability to secure learner numbers, led to many instructors leaving their Japanese teaching positions for jobs with better working conditions, such as tour guiding. Satomi (2016) noted the lack of instructors who could teach N4 level Japanese at private schools and reported that learners at N4 and higher levels had no choice but to engage in self-study. Additionally, in recent years, multiple institutions, including 8 institutions in Nairobi, have ended their programs due to various complications such as inability to secure learner numbers or lack of (qualified) instructors (Nakamura, 2020).

Table 1 gives a summary of the numbers of Japanese language learners and JLPT examinees in Kenya since 2009, obtained from several publications by JF on JLE overseas.

Table 1 Number of Japanese learners and JLPT examinees in Kenya since 2009

	2009	2010	2011	2012	2013	2014	2015	2016	2017	2018	2019	2020	2021	2022	2023
Learners	988 (711)	—	—	1768 (735)	—	—	1107 (513)	—	—	*2573 (709)	—	—	1726 (542)	—	—
JLPT examinees	110	131	89	61	78	55	58	42	49	51	59	0	38	42	53

Note: JF does not provide annual data on the number of learners; *The validity of part of the 2018 statistics released was questioned by some parties (Abe, 2021); Numbers in round brackets represent the number of learners at tertiary institutions

Kagama (2023) documents that there were approximately 25 instructors affiliated with the Japanese Language Teachers' Association of Kenya (JALTAK) in 2023.

3. The Survey: Objectives and targets

The survey sought to reveal the prevailing state of JLEK mainly from the perspectives of instructors and current, past and potential learners. In past research on JLEK, attention has not been paid to potential learners and past learners. However, this survey found it important to include them with the aim of examining the factors that hinder them from beginning or progressing with their study of Japanese. Moreover, the study investigated the conditions of Japanese language programs offered at tertiary institutions in Kenya as of 2023. In the case of the instructors, the study focused on their education/training levels, teaching experience, teaching materials, information on JLE programs at their institutions, their views regarding how JLEK can be advanced, etc. Regarding the learners/potential learners, the study investigated issues such as:

- (a) Current motivating factors in the learning of Japanese in Kenya.
- (b) The reasons why potential learners have not begun learning Japanese.
- (c) Reasons why those who stopped learning Japanese did so.
- (d) Learning resources in use and their advantages/disadvantages.
- (e) (Preferred) mode of delivery of the lessons.

4. Methodology

4-1 Participants & survey tools

The instructors of Japanese who participated in this survey were from tertiary institutions since, as mentioned above, the actual learning of Japanese in Kenya mainly takes place in tertiary institutions. They

participated through semi-structured, in-depth interviews conducted in either English or Japanese, depending on the preference of each interviewee. This was to ensure information connected to the main areas of interest was obtained, while allowing for additional information to be provided. Each interviewee could choose to be interviewed either online or in-person. The total number of instructors of Japanese language at tertiary institutions in Kenya at the time of the survey was 12 and they were all affiliated with the JALTAK. All volunteered to participate in the survey (a sample size of 100%) upon being requested. The average interview time was 64.5 minutes. Cumulatively, 9 Kenyan tertiary institutions (both public and private), located in Nairobi, Kiambu, and Nyeri counties were engaged in JLEK in 2023, and they all cooperated in this study (100% representation). More details on the cooperating institutions are given in table 2 under part 5-1.

The learners participated through an online questionnaire administered through Google Forms. The link to the questionnaire was sent to the instructors who shared it with their learners, both past and current, primarily through the social media platform WhatsApp. WhatsApp is a popular tool of communication in Kenya. Sauke (2021) in their study on the role of WhatsApp in learning by University of Nairobi graduate students concludes that, “There is no doubt that digital technology is of significance in education today. WhatsApp mobile technology is (sic) extremely valuable in this regard, as it is widely and extensively employed in online university education”. Sauke (2021) adds that, “The WhatsApp mobile communication technology has been discovered to be one of the most helpful methods of learning”. All the instructors who participated in this survey had active WhatsApp groups for their respective classes (and for classes they taught in the past) through which they conveniently send announcements and share other useful information with their learners.

Additionally, the link to the questionnaire was shared on the official Facebook pages of the JALTAK and the “Kenya Nihongo Hiroba”. Both pages are followed by people who are/have been interested/involved in the teaching and learning of Japanese in Kenya, and are used to disseminate information related to JLEK such as speech contests, conferences, JLPT, etc. Notably, the 2 pages were highly instrumental in obtaining responses from potential and past learners. The questionnaire had 492 respondents, whose details are discussed further under section 5.

The combination of qualitative and quantitative methods of data collection and analysis, with interviews for instructors and the questionnaire for learners, was geared at attaining a wholesome picture of the prevailing situation of JLEK. The goal was to investigate the issues affecting access to JLE and learner retention in JLE by interested Kenyans. This combination of methods also made it possible to get more detailed information from the instructors regarding some of the intriguing responses received from learners through the questionnaire, such as the ones related to “desire to study in Japan as a motivating factor to learn Japanese”, which is discussed in part 5-3-1. Past surveys by JF have focused more on institutions, with others that included learners (e.g. Wamuti, 2021) getting data from current learners on specific topics such as learner motivation. Potential and past learners have largely been left out in studies conducted before 2023, and this study sought to fill that gap by including as many current, past, and potential learners as possible.

The survey tools can be accessed through the following link:

https://researchmap.jp/njerikagemaresearch/published_papers/48271773/attachment_file.pdf

4-2 Ethical considerations

Ethical clearance to conduct this survey was obtained from Tohoku University. Thereafter, a research license to conduct the survey was acquired from the National Commission for Science, Technology & Innovation (NACOSTI) in Kenya. Permission to collect data from the participating institutions was also obtained from the respective institutions.

The instructors were made aware of their rights as interviewees before the interviews began, and they were interviewed after reading the explanation form, orally affirming their willingness to participate, and signing a consent form. They also consented to their interviews being audio recorded upon being assured of confidential treatment of the data obtained from them. Interviewees were free to decline to answer any questions they did not wish to.

The Google Form's explanation section stated that participation in the questionnaire was voluntary and that minors (under 18 years old) who were potential respondents would have their parents send their responses on their behalf, though it was anticipated that the number of minors participating in the study would be negligible.

5. Survey Findings

5-1 Data pertaining to institutions offering Japanese language in Kenya (2023)

As of December 2023, no institution in Kenya offered Japanese as a degree major. Below is an overview of the 9 tertiary institutions offering Japanese language in Kenya as of December 2023.

Table 2 Institutions with Japanese language Programs in Kenya (December 2023)

Institution Code	Type	Location	Ownership	Instructors	Learners	Program type	Teaching mode	Japanese taught to the public?
A	University	Kiambu	Public	1J, 2K	319	*Non-credit *Elective *Degree minor	In-person	No
B	University	Nairobi	Private	1J	95	*Elective *Degree minor	In-person	No
C	University	Nairobi	Private	2K	69	*Elective	Blended	No
D	University	Kiambu	Public	1K	13	*Non-credit *Certificate course	In-person	Yes
E	Specialized college	Nairobi	Public	1J, 1K	51	*Elective	In-person	No
F	Specialized College	Nairobi	Private	1K	25	*Elective *Certificate course	In-person	Yes
G	College	Nairobi	Private	1K	18	*Elective *Certificate course	Blended	Yes
H	College	Nairobi	Private	1K	25	*Elective *Certificate course	Blended	Yes
I	College	Nyeri	Private	1K	8	*Certificate course	In-person	Yes

Total number of learners: 623

Total number of instructors (both part-time and full-time): 12 (part-time instructors may teach at more than one institution)

Note: On the Instructors' column, "J" stands for "Japanese", and "K" for Kenyan.

"Blended" mode of delivery here refers to a system in which a certain percentage of lessons are held online, while the rest is held in-person. This differs from "hybrid" classes in which some participants attend in-person while others attend online, simultaneously.

5-2 Findings from instructors

5-2-1 Education and training levels

The instructors were 9 Kenyan and 3 Japanese nationals, with different levels of education ranging from a college diploma to a PhD. 9 out of the 12 instructors who were interviewed had attained a master's level education or above. However, their fields of study were varied, ranging from JLE to linguistics, educational technology, communication, literature, tourism, ICT, etc. It was also established that all the instructors who participated in this study had acquired some training in JLE.

The time spent on JLE training, however, could be argued to be very short in some cases, with all the 9 Kenyan instructors having taken teacher training courses offered by JF for periods varying between 2 and 9 months, and only 1 out of the 9 advancing their training to Master's degree level, still under JF sponsorship.

Regarding how the instructors perceived their level of training, 3 termed their training levels as “not enough”, while the majority (8 out of 12) reported that they are able to achieve their teaching goals but would benefit from further training. Notably, more training was demanded in the areas of kanji (6 out of 12) and culture (4 out of 12). Grammar was mentioned by 2 respondents.

The instructors who reported difficulty in teaching culture asserted that due to limited opportunities to travel to Japan and engage directly with Japanese culture, there is a gap that is felt especially when the learners ask questions related to Japan and Japanese culture, even though they try to use informative videos in their culture classes.

Through the interviews, it was also deduced that the training of Kenyan instructors of Japanese language is heavily reliant on the JF sponsorship. Training of instructors through sponsorship from other sources accounts for less than 20% of the Japanese language instructors at tertiary institutions in Kenya. This may be seen as an indicator of minimal effort by local Kenyan institutions to invest in JLE.

The training by JF is mainly conducted in Japan. While this is an opportunity for the trainees to get immersed in the Japanese language and culture environment, the fact that concrete training (not including occasional seminars) only takes place in Japan poses some challenges according to the respondents.

According to the instructors, JF teacher training programs accept only one participant from Kenya in any year and therefore, applying for the training does not guarantee that one will participate in the program at their desired time. One respondent noted that while only one Kenyan can participate per year, more participants from Asian countries are sponsored, and probably that may be a factor towards the growth of JLE in such countries. It may be assumed that the decision to include more participants from Asian countries lies in the fact that there are more learners in those countries and a higher demand for teachers from such countries to be trained. However, to advance JLEK, it is crucial to increase training opportunities for Kenyan instructors.

Still on training, another hindrance that was reported is the lack of local teacher training programs. In line with this, the interviewees pointed out that the JF teacher training programs have an age limit. The 2023 program guidelines released by the JF indicate priority for individuals “aged 55 years or under” (Japan Foundation, 2023). At least 5 Kenyan respondents were over the age of 50 at the time of the survey, and while JF guidelines did not expressly indicate that applications by individuals above the age of 55 would be rejected, the interviewees felt that applicants above the age of 55 would not be successful if they applied. Furthermore, some respondents reported that due to their family, work, or health situations, they could not travel to Japan

even if they had the opportunity to and would benefit from local training programs if they were to be conducted in Kenya.

It is also noteworthy that one of the interviewees stressed that for Kenya to have any meaningful training of Japanese language instructors, first and foremost, a curriculum of JLEK must be created. The interviewee argued that teacher training should always be geared towards meeting educational needs which should be stipulated in a curriculum, and therefore, without the curriculum, optimal training cannot be achieved.

When we observe the situation of teacher training in the African continent, with Egypt as a trailblazer, we see a different trend. Japan Foundation (2020) reports that by October 2020, 65 teachers of Japanese had completed a training course offered at the Japan Foundation, Cairo (Egypt). Further, Japan Foundation (2024a) reports that after changing the course into an online program from 2021, and resultantly enabling trainees from not just Egypt but also the Middle East and North Africa to take the course, approximately 100 of them had completed their studies and were teaching in various institutions as of February 2024.

5-2-2 Low instructor numbers

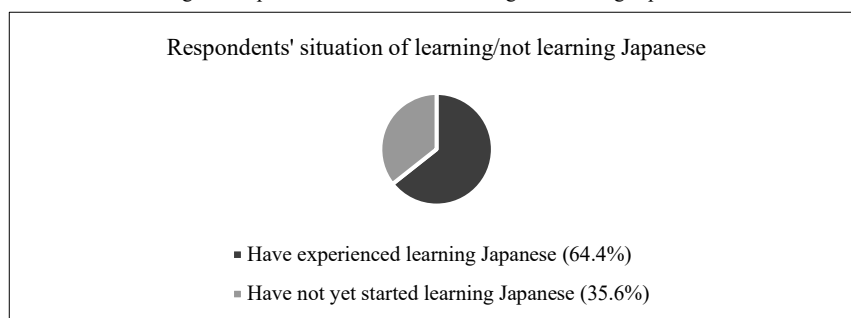
As of December 2023, the total number of JALTAK members was approximately 25, with only 12 instructors at tertiary institutions.

The shortage of qualified Japanese language instructors has further been compounded by the dire financial situation being experienced by Kenyan educational institutions, especially public universities, in recent years (Samoei & Makau, 2022). This has reduced their capabilities to hire new personnel even on a part-time basis, with the general trend being downsizing. Downsizing has been characterized by changes such as the merging of departments and retrenchments (Nyamai, 2022). Moreover, with Japanese not being in the Kenyan education curriculum, it can be assumed that the Kenyan government may not proactively invest its resources towards the advancement of JLEK.

5-3 Findings from learners and potential learners

The 492 participants in this category comprised learners studying Japanese at institutions, those taking private classes, those engaged in self-study, people who studied Japanese in the past, and people interested in studying Japanese, but who have not yet started for various reasons that will be discussed hereafter. Those with experience of studying Japanese accounted for 64.4% while those who have not yet started studying Japanese (potential learners) accounted for 35.6% of the responses.

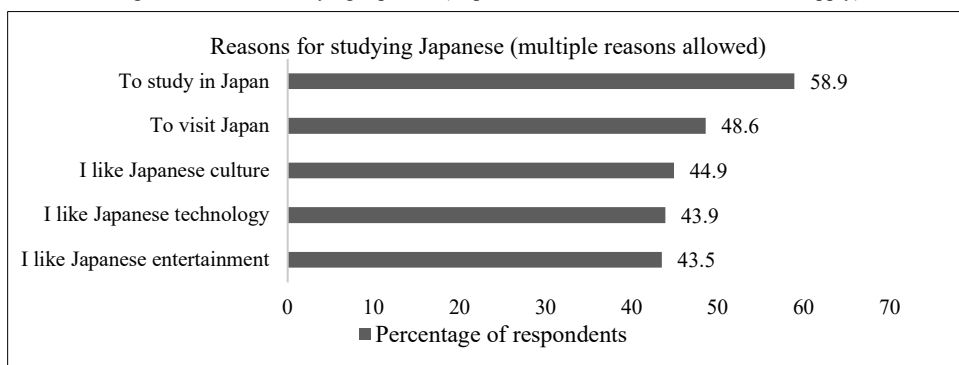
Fig 1 Respondents' situation of learning/not learning Japanese



5-3-1 Learners' motivation to study Japanese

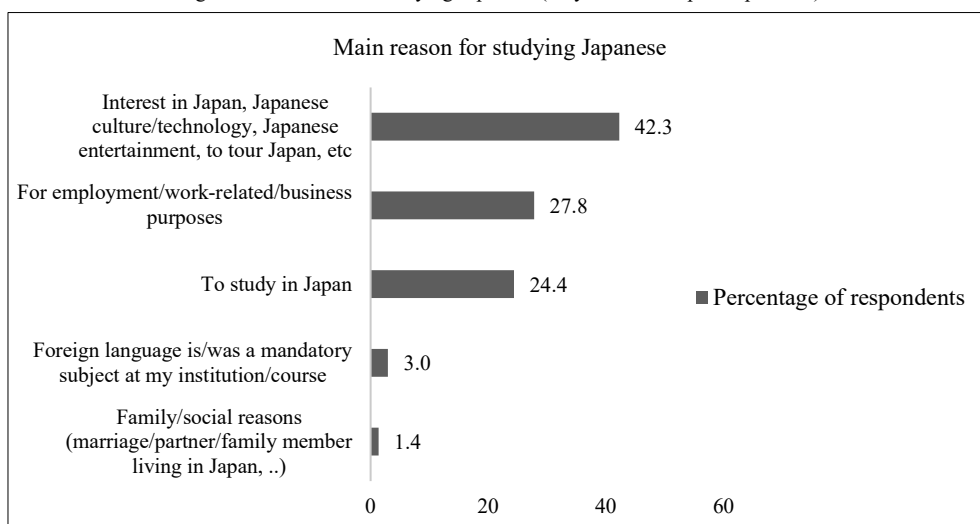
There were two questionnaire entries that addressed this point. The first question required checking all applicable boxes from a list of several entries, while the second required the respondent to choose the main reason (only one) why they study Japanese. In the case of the first question, the 5 most chosen reasons were as shown in Fig 2.

Fig 2 Reasons for studying Japanese (respondents could choose all reasons that apply)



However, in the second question, in which some choices were merged and respondents could only choose one (main) reason, the 5 most selected reasons were as shown in Fig 3:

Fig 3 Main reason for studying Japanese (only one reason per respondent)



Most of the questionnaire respondents (84.6%) were 25 years old or younger. When we analyze the results of the questions regarding the motivation to study Japanese, it may be surprising to note the difference in the responses related to “to study in Japan”. When multiple reasons could be selected, it comes first place. When only one reason could be chosen, it comes in third place.

A possible explanation for this could be that the desire to visit Japan is so strong for some of the respondents that an opportunity to study in Japan could mainly be a means to get to Japan and experience the country but not the biggest motivation. Most of the Kenyans studying in Japan do so on scholarships and therefore it is possible that to some, a scholarship opportunity to study in Japan is a chance to achieve their dream of visiting/

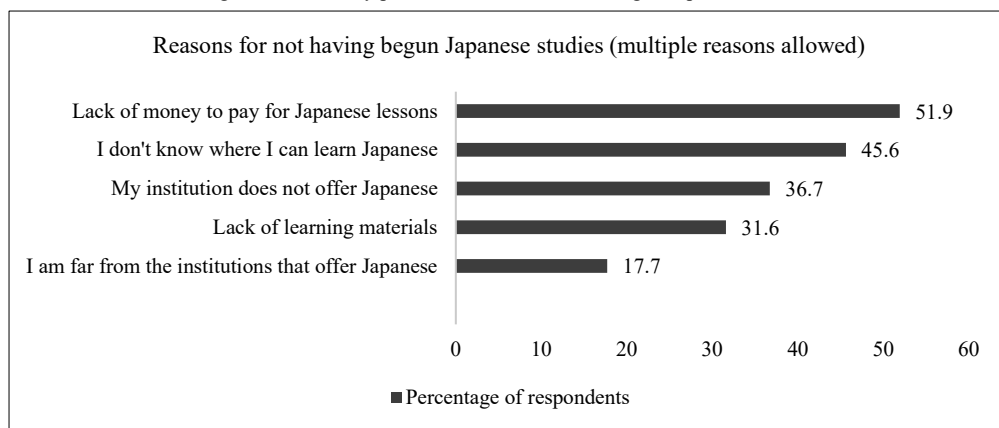
experiencing Japan with minimal financial liability. The World Tourism Organization (2016) reports of increasing numbers of youth travelers who are “interested to “live like a local”, an immersive experience which also means they tend to spend directly with local businesses and make close contact with local culture and residents”.

This finding necessitated an interview with the office appointed by the Japanese Government to promote “study in Japan” in Kenya¹(including giving information regarding scholarships to Kenyans) at the time of the survey. The interview was to help make projections on how “study in Japan” promotion activities would affect JLEK henceforth. Based on information received from instructors, a significant increase in learner numbers in institutions where “study in Japan” events were held had been observed, especially since late 2022. This could also explain the rise in learner numbers at tertiary institutions from 542 in 2021 (JF statistics) to the 623 recorded in this survey. However, it was understood through the interview that the office would close in March 2024. Consequently, it is possible that the increasing trend of learner numbers that had resulted from their events could change.

5-3-2 The current situation of (not) learning Japanese

As mentioned earlier, 35.6% of the respondents had not yet started learning Japanese, despite their desire to do so. One of the questionnaire entries investigated the reasons for this, in which the respondents were free to choose multiple reasons. The 5 major responses to the question were as shown in Fig 4.

Fig 4 Reasons why potential learners have not begun Japanese studies.



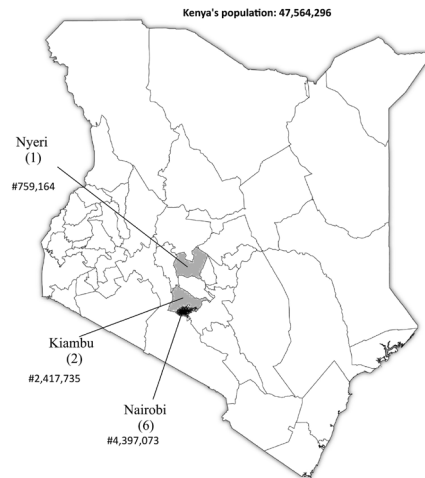
Based on the above responses, we can infer that most potential learners are yet to start their Japanese studies due to reasons that are not within their control. The reasons are related to the difficulty to access Japanese language programs, either at the institutional level or through private tutorship. The cost factor stands out, although in this survey, it was not specified whether the inability to afford to pay for Japanese lessons was at institutional or at private tutorship level.

Next, I will look further into the issue of Japanese program accessibility from 2 main angles. The first angle has to do with Japanese programs at institutional level. The second angle has to do with access to private tutorship.

The 9 institutions that offered Japanese language courses in Kenya in 2023 are in or near Nairobi, the capital of Kenya. As such, we can only imagine how many Kenyans would like to learn Japanese but are far from the

institutions. Nairobi and Kiambu counties, both appearing on the map, are the 2 most populous counties in Kenya (Kenya National Bureau of Statistics, 2019).

Fig 5 Map of Kenyan counties with tertiary institutions that offered Japanese language programs as of December 2023. Number in round brackets represents the number of institutions per county; Number followed by sharp sign (#) represents county population.



Moreover, 4 out of the 9 institutions that offered Japanese in 2023 do not offer Japanese classes to the public (people who are not regular students), based on the information from the instructors. It would be convenient if all the 9 institutions had programs that accommodate people who are only interested in learning Japanese.

What is even more unfortunate, is that, based on personal observations from visits to the respective institutions in 2023, the institutions which do not offer Japanese programs to the public have better facilities necessary for classroom teaching and learning of Japanese. These include modern audio-visual media, libraries with resources for learning Japanese, and in 3 institutions, native Japanese instructors alongside Kenyan instructors. Hence, they can be said to have a relatively rich potential for intercultural exchange. The concerning lack of resources, especially teaching/learning materials, in institutions offering Japanese classes to the public will be discussed further under section 5-4.

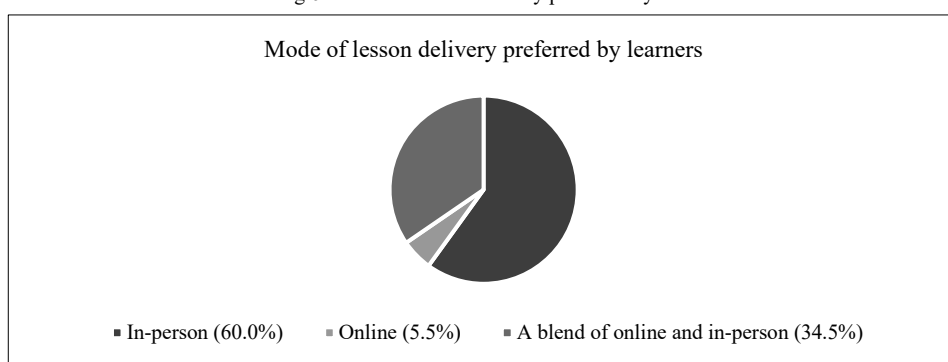
The problem of not having institutions with Japanese programs in counties far from Nairobi could probably be neutralized by having online programs by the institutions which offer Japanese to the public. However, out of the total 9 institutions executing JLE, 6 of them had their programs held 100% in-person, while 3 of them had a blended approach, i.e., having physical lessons on some days and online lessons on other days of the week. No institution had a program conducted fully through online channels, and we can only imagine how the situation would change if such programs were to be available to the public. The uptake of such programs, however, could possibly be affected by dynamics such as the mode of delivery preferred by the learners, to be discussed hereafter.

Concerning private tutorship, it is important to note that not all JALTAK members give private lessons. A total of 11 members had registered as private tutors as of December 2023. This number includes instructors who are not engaged in teaching Japanese at tertiary institutions and does not include native Japanese instructors as they had not signed up for private lessons, probably due to the demands of their full-time jobs at

their respective institutions. However, a Japanese language specialist dispatched by the JF had been conducting a 2-hour trial lesson at the Embassy of Japan in Kenya monthly since April 2023 (Kagama, 2023) to introduce Japanese to the Kenyan public. After experiencing the trial lesson, those interested in continuing with Japanese studies would be guided on how to access Japanese programs either at institutions or under private tutors. In addition, there was one Japanese national unaffiliated with JALTAK, who had been offering Japanese lessons as a private tutor at the time of the survey.

Let us now focus on the mode of delivery demanded by learners/potential learners in relation to the mode of delivery offered by the private tutors. In the questionnaire, the following question was posed to all respondents: “What mode of delivery would you PREFER your teacher/institution to use for Japanese lessons? This applies to all, including those studying by themselves (assuming that a teacher was available to teach them)”. The responses to this question are shown in Fig 6.

Fig 6 Mode of lesson delivery preferred by learners



The 2023 internal record of JALTAK members that engage in private tutorship showed that out of the 11 private tutors, only 6 were offering in-person lessons. This could mean that people who are not inclined to online learning may encounter yet another barrier in cases where they are far from the instructor(s) who offer in-person classes of their level. Moreover, it may be possible that some potential learners would only benefit from in-person lessons due to Internet access issues. The challenges related to learning Japanese online in Kenya, including poor Internet connectivity in some areas and the cost of Internet services, have been discussed by Kagema (2021).

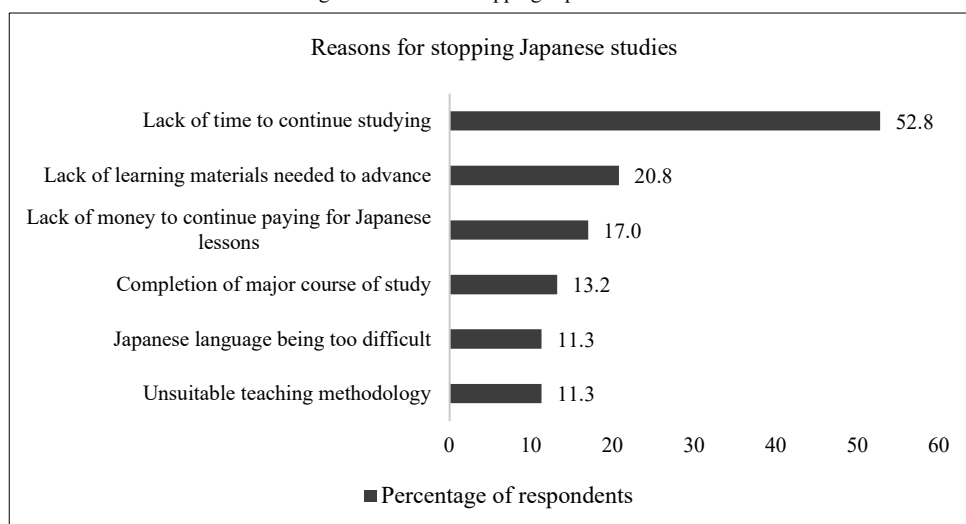
5-3-3 The situation of those who stopped learning Japanese

A question was posed to the participants who have experienced studying Japanese to confirm whether they are still learning Japanese. 87.9% responded in the affirmative, while 12.1% responded in the negative. The reasons given by those who stopped are shown in Fig 7.

Lack of time to continue studying is something that we cannot dissect very deeply since we do not know the circumstances of each individual case. We can only assume that there were reasons such as academic burdens, career demands, family responsibilities, etc.

Regarding the (lack of) opportunities to progress to higher levels of proficiency, it is worth noting that as of 2023, there were only two universities in Kenya offering Japanese as a minor degree program, and as per the instructors' responses in the interviews, learners taking Japanese as a degree minor normally attain JLPT N4-N3 level proficiency.

Fig 7 Reasons for stopping Japanese studies



According to the data collected in this study through the instructors' interviews, most of the instructors offering private lessons only hold a JLPT N3 or lower level of Japanese proficiency, which is insufficient to teach levels beyond elementary Japanese. Most of the JALTAK members with higher levels of Japanese proficiency (both Japanese and Kenyan) do not offer private classes, and therefore it may be claimed that there is a gap between the availability of private tutors and the skills held by those who are available. From the findings of this survey, we can say that the situation described by Satomi (2016), discussed in Section 2, has not changed much.

The situation of N4 and higher-level learners having to study by themselves then automatically requires us to focus on the learning materials available. Lack of materials to advance in Japanese studies was indicated at second place, by 20.8% of the respondents who stopped learning Japanese. The issue of learning materials will be discussed in detail in section 5-4.

The third reason given was lack of money to continue paying for Japanese lessons (17%). This issue of cost also came up as the biggest reason why potential learners had not started studying Japanese. More research needs to be carried out regarding the economic aspects associated with access to Japanese language programs by Kenyans, so that solutions to the problem can be proposed.

Japanese language being too difficult, and the use of unsuitable teaching methodology were each chosen by 11.3% of respondents who stopped learning Japanese. We cannot deny that these two issues are intertwined since it is obvious that poor teaching methodology cannot yield sufficient understanding of the content being delivered. Problems arising from poor teaching methodologies can only be countered through adequate training of the instructors.

5-4 Findings on teaching and learning materials

The instructors' interview included the question, "which materials/textbooks do you use? If several, highlight the main". The answers to this question featured textbooks, with 10 out of 12 instructors saying that they use *Minna no Nihongo* as their main material, 1 reporting that they use *Japanese for Hotel Staff* to teach their learners who take courses in hospitality, and only 1 saying that *Marugoto* is their main material. On

probing further, instructors indicated that they use *Minna no Nihongo* due to the following reasons:

- a) Systematic organization of content
- b) Its ease of use, since it accommodates everyone (as compared to other books that may be for specialized language use)
- c) Good explanation of grammar and a lot of practice exercises
- d) Examples given at the beginning of every exercise
- e) Familiarity with the book (as the instructors themselves learned Japanese using the same book)
- f) Its suitability for learners who want to take the JLPT
- g) Its availability (in some cases, it is the only book available).

Marugoto was termed by the majority of instructors as “too difficult to use” or “requiring too much effort on the part of the instructor when teaching”.

In the case of the instructor who said that *Marugoto* is their main material, the reason given was that *Marugoto* materials could be freely and legitimately accessed online, hence any learner could acquire the material easily. They added that, “being more recent than the other materials, *Marugoto* tends to be more application based than grammar based”. This respondent also indicated that *Marugoto* was ideal for teaching Japanese culture, and therefore was a good choice since their institution of affiliation offers foreign language education not focusing much on language proficiency but as an avenue for learners to gain global understanding. It should be noted, though, that the institution that this respondent belongs to had 2 Japanese language instructors, with the second one being a *Minna no Nihongo* user. However, this instructor, as well as the one who reported using *Japanese for Hotel Staff*, mentioned that in the cases where detailed grammar explanation is necessary, they use *Minna no Nihongo*. Considering these responses, we can say that every instructor of Japanese at Kenya’s tertiary institutions uses *Minna no Nihongo* to some extent.

Through the questionnaire that gave each learner the chance to indicate all the books that they use, 91% of the learners indicated that they use(d) *Minna no Nihongo*, and 10.2% indicated that they use(d) *Genki*. However, it should be noted that those who use(d) *Genki* alone (without any other book), accounted for a mere 2.4%, while those who use(d) *Minna no Nihongo* alone accounted for more than 50% of the responses. Other books that were featured included *Marugoto* (2.9%) and *Japanese for Busy People* (2.9%), though they were not the only textbooks used by the respondents who highlighted them.

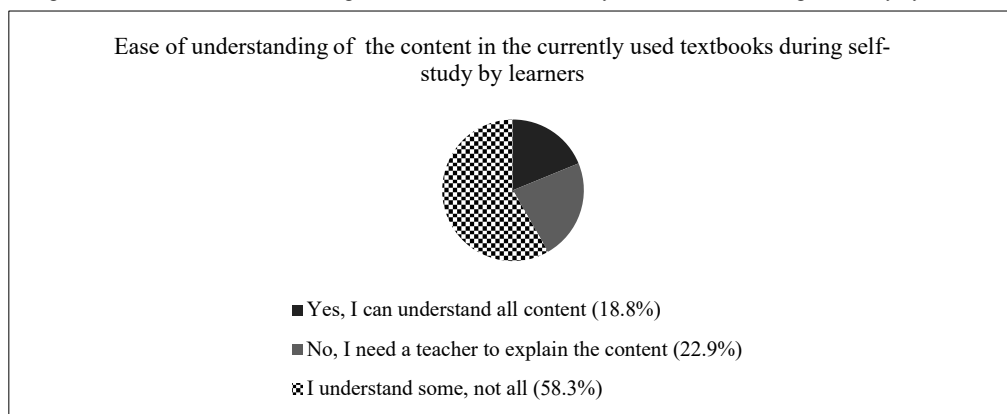
The questionnaire further investigated how easy it was for Kenyan learners to understand the content in the Japanese textbooks. The question posed was: “Do you think that the textbook you used/are using is easy for you to understand when you STUDY ALONE?” The responses received were as shown in Fig 8.

From the data, it is clear that less than 20% of Kenyan learners of Japanese can successfully use the currently available materials for self-study. In addition to textbooks, approximately 60% of the learners indicated that they use(d) smart device apps. Out of the apps highlighted, *Duolingo* was at 73.1%, while many others had smaller percentages of users.

Let us now focus on what the instructors, through the interviews, said would be an “ideal textbook”, if a textbook were to be designed specifically for Kenyan learners of Japanese.

While the systematic organization of content in *Minna no Nihongo* was noted by all the instructors who participated in this survey, on the other hand, they said that the book lacks “Kenyan context”. Other issues that

Fig 8 Level of ease of understanding of the content in the currently used textbooks during self-study by learners



arose as weaknesses of *Minna no Nihongo* were as follows: “Pictures that are not easy to understand”, “black and white pictures that are not appealing”, and “lack of explanations on Japanese culture in the main textbook, which is the one that is mostly available”. *Minna no Nihongo* has supplementary texts that cover various topics, though they are not readily available in Kenya.

The instructors stressed their fulltime efforts to incorporate Kenyan elements (places, objects, etc.) in their lessons to adapt the content of *Minna no Nihongo* to the Kenyan learners’ environment. One of the words that several instructors reported to incorporate in their lessons was *matatu* (minibuses popularly used as public transport vehicles in Kenya), among others.

Further, the instructors communicated their desire to have a textbook whose setting is in Kenya, so that the Kenyan learners of Japanese can feel closer to the content presented in the lesson.

Regarding the presentation of content in the most often used textbooks in Kenya, this author is presently conducting a textbook analysis in a separate study, investigating how the presentation of content in those books may affect the learning outcomes of Japanese language in Kenya.

The problem of textbooks does not end at the “lack of Kenyan context”. At the fundamental level, the availability of textbooks is an issue that cannot be ignored. From the data collected in this survey, two matters arose: access to textbooks, and the age of the textbooks. Only 2 institutions, which happen to be private, claimed adequate access to textbooks for all their learners. In all the other institutions, there was a scarce supply of textbooks, with one textbook per more than 10 students on average. So critical is the problem of lack of textbooks that in 3 institutions, only the instructors had a textbook. Moreover, it was revealed that only 3 institutions out of the 9 use the updated version of *Minna no Nihongo*, with all the others using the 1998 version that includes obsolete vocabulary, which was revised in the 2012 edition.

According to many instructors, the unproportionate number of books versus users has led to the inevitable and uncontrollable scanning and photocopying of the textbooks by many learners. This consequently leads to another problem of copyright infringement which cannot be ignored.

Considering the financial issues faced by Kenyan institutions stated earlier, and the high costs that would be involved if (updated) textbooks were to be imported, it may be unlikely that Kenyan institutions will embark on purchasing textbooks from Japan. This situation then demands that stakeholders of JLEK come up with a lasting solution to the problems concerning textbooks/learning materials that have been discussed in this paper.

A viable solution to this problem could be to develop textbooks that are designed for Kenyans and available for distribution in Kenya.

6. The overall situation of JLEK as of 2023 as revealed through the survey

As of December 4th, 2023, JLEK was mainly conducted at 9 tertiary institutions, with a total of 12 instructors and 623 learners. The main motivation for learning Japanese in Kenya at the time was “interest in Japan, Japanese culture, technology, etc.” No institution offered Japanese as a degree major, though it was offered as a minor degree course at 2 universities. Japanese is mostly learned up to the beginner level, while those who take the degree minor learn up to JLPT N4 or N3 level. However, a considerable number of Kenyans interested in learning Japanese could not access JLE, mostly due to economic issues and difficulty in accessing Japanese programs at the institutional level.

Minna no Nihongo was the main textbook used in Kenya, though it was not easily accessible to learners. As documented in previous studies, the lack of materials designed for Kenyan learners was noted as one of the factors that inhibit the acquisition of Japanese by Kenyans. Teacher training opportunities were found to be insufficient and reliant on JF sponsorship.

7. Summary and recommendations

This needs survey sought information on various matters pertaining to JLEK such as the motivating reasons to study Japanese, the barriers hindering access to and progression in JLE, the study resources in use, the qualifications of instructors, etc. As efforts are made towards the holistic advancement of JLEK, this survey shed light on the urgency to pay attention to the following issues:

First, the small number of unevenly distributed institutions offering Japanese in Kenya, and more so, through in-person or blended modes of delivery mostly to their regular students, may be one of the biggest hurdles towards making JLEK more accessible. I recommend that the institutions executing JLEK adjust or increase their programs to include members of the public from all parts of Kenya who are interested in learning Japanese, regardless of student status. This may be through using online meeting platforms such as Zoom or offering hybrid or on-demand lessons.

Second, problems regarding learning materials became apparent, and notably, the lack of materials was shown to be one of the major factors leading to the discontinuation of Japanese studies in Kenya. Moreover, as noted in previous research, the currently used textbooks lack Kenyan context, and their suitability for the Kenyan learner is questioned. In line with this, I recommend the development of materials that are targeted at the Kenyan learner of Japanese, available for distribution in Kenya, and which can make it significantly easier for Kenyans to learn Japanese through self-study. As revealed through this survey, many Kenyans cannot access Japanese language programs due to economic reasons, and as such, having textbooks that can be used at the level of self-study may be one step further towards achieving the goals of advancing JLEK. Additionally, when the recommended textbooks designed for Kenyans are supplemented by the currently used textbooks, we can expect that the experience of learning Japanese for Kenyans would be enriched remarkably.

Finally, considering the findings of this study and previous literature on JLEK, I recommend the establishment of a stable teacher training program in Kenya such as the one executed by the Japan Foundation,

Cairo, in Egypt. This will be instrumental in sustaining instructor numbers and upholding high standards of instructor qualifications in Kenya, where ideally, Japanese could be learned from beginner to advanced levels. It will also help in overcoming the current situation of lack of advanced level Japanese programs in Kenya, which was also cited in previous studies on JLEK.

This study exposed the various issues impeding the advancement of JLEK, which will need to be addressed by stakeholders of JLEK moving forward. I conclude by emphasizing that the advancement of JLEK demands a multi-faceted approach, and diligent, collective efforts by all stakeholders will be key in solving the current challenges.

Footnotes

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ケニアの日本語教育の促進を目指して

——2023 年のニーズ調査からの考察——

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ケニアにおける日本語教育（以下、JLEK）は1975年に始まった。以来主に高等教育機関で課外科目、選択科目、副専攻として日本語が教えられているが、JLEKのために教師や学習者を対象にした定期的なニーズ調査は行われていない。

本稿は2023年に行われたJLEKの活動に対するニーズ調査の結果を報告する。調査は現職の教師や学習者に加えて、潜在的な学習者や過去の学習者を対象にJLEKへのアクセスと継続性についての問題を把握するために実施された。

調査結果に基づき、筆者はJLEKの活動の発展を促進、あるいは阻害する要因を検討した。課題として日本語教育へのアクセス、適切な教師研修の実施、学習教材に関する問題等が明らかになった。これらを踏まえ、筆者は教師研修プログラムへの投資、JLEKを実施している全機関による社会人対象の日本語プログラムの提供、ケニアの日本語学習者に適した自習用の教材の開発等を提案した。

【キーワード】 ケニアにおける日本語教育（JLEK）、ニーズ調査、ケニアの日本語学習者、日本語教材、日本語教師研修

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